

## **We are EENJOY: Demonstrating ELTE's Experience-Based Platform for First-Year Induction with ARG Elements**

The transition to higher education confronts first-year students with unfamiliar systems, fragile belonging, and peer networks that must be built from scratch. Research identifies belonging as the critical mechanism linking engagement to retention (Thomas, 2012), yet conventional induction still relies on passive sessions. While Kift's transition pedagogy (2010) calls for integrated approaches, few institutions have explored how gamification and narrative design might serve this goal, and those that have, such as Ghent University's gamified orientation day (Vanderstraeten et al., 2025), remain limited to single-event interventions.

This session demonstrates EENJOY, an experience-based gamification platform developed at ELTE (Eötvös Loránd University, Hungary) that extends gamified induction into a semester-long ecosystem. Aligned with the EU Digital Education Action Plan's emphasis on innovative pedagogy, EENJOY combines time-limited Challenges (campus exploration and social activities), Quests (story missions), and a seasonal Alternate Reality Game narrative where each cohort collaboratively investigates a self-contained mystery.

Participants will see the platform in action: how challenges guide students through real university spaces, how a social feed connects participants across faculties, and how ARG elements – designed around an "iceberg structure" – serve different engagement tiers. We walk through challenge design examples, demonstrate the narrative layer, and share physical props used at events.

Our pilot (2023–2024, n=2,735) achieved 23% brand awareness and 9% registration. User feedback was positive (85% UI satisfaction, 81% usability). ARG participants demonstrated deeper critical engagement, suggesting narrative framing adds qualitative depth that points-and-badges gamification alone does not.

We also address practical realities. Platform development was outsourced to an external partner after over a year of collaborative specification, meaning the institution bears no direct development workload but depends on an external team for bug fixes and feature iterations. Internally, a core team of four handles daily operations – challenge design, moderation, and creative direction – which we consider a bare minimum; scaling beyond the pilot requires additional capacity. Institutional acceptance demands continuous advocacy, as the project resists easy categorization within university structures. Despite these challenges, we find that narrative-driven gamification scaffolds campus exploration effectively, tiered structures accommodate diverse preferences, and ARG elements generate exceptional depth – though the approach's transferability depends on what each institution can realistically commit.